

THE COOKOUT CONFESSION

A Contained Ensemble Dramedy

Written by Kelly R. Tenney | Feature · 90 pages · Single Location | NCCA Entertainment, Atlanta

LOGLINE

On the day she plans to end her marriage in front of her oldest friends, a woman's hunt for her husband's mistress forces five women to confess the secrets they have been keeping from each other, and from themselves, before the sun goes down.

THE STORY

Every Fourth of July, five college friends gather at Celeste Carter's Charlotte backyard for the cookout that has outlasted every marriage, move, and falling-out in the group. This year, Celeste has a toast, a countdown to sunset, and an ultimatum: confess who slept with her husband, or she exposes everyone's secrets when the light goes. Over one unraveling afternoon (sprinklers, a locked briefcase, a torn hotel folio, a DUI nobody knew about), the mystery Celeste built turns out to be a mirror. What her friends have really been protecting her from is the truth she has been running from for twenty years.

WHY NOW

Contained & producible	One backyard, one kitchen, one day. Six principal roles, no stunts, no company moves: a full emotional engine on an efficient budget.
Showcase ensemble	Six meaty roles for actors 40–50, built for a marquee cast announcement and awards-conversation performances.
A twist that is actually about something	The whodunit structure is a closet metaphor: audiences get a mystery and a real reckoning with shame, silence, and chosen family.

PLATFORM FIT

BET+	Community at the center, Black excellence and Black struggle held together, ensemble catharsis in the vein of <i>First Wives Club</i> .
HBO / Hulu	Morally complex, character-driven, no sanitizing, with the closed-door tension of <i>Insecure</i> at feature length.

COMPS *Big Little Lies* meets *Waiting to Exhale*, with the single-location pressure-cooker of *August: Osage County*.

TONE Sharp ensemble comedy colliding with real stakes: laughs that never let anyone off the hook.

Suggested Cast

Illustrative casting directions for early conversations, not offers, availabilities, or attachments.

CELESTE CARTER

45 · Lead

Elegant, exacting, performing composure until it cracks. Carries the film's central self-deception.

Meagan Good · Kerry Washington

MARCUS CARTER

47 · Lead

A doctor who calms everyone else's emergencies and cannot name his own. Steady, then finally not.

Sterling K. Brown · Jesse Williams

MONA BENNETT

46 · Supporting

The friend who manages everyone's crisis instead of naming her own. Control as a love language.

Tika Sumpter · Nicole Ari Parker

RENEE WATKINS

43 · Supporting

A therapist unraveling in the one room where she cannot curate herself. Warm, composed, breaking quietly.

DeWanda Wise · Emayatzy Corinealdi

TASHA PRICE

44 · Supporting

Comic relief with real stakes: a gallery owner one bad month from losing everything, funniest person in every room she is scared in.

Yvonne Orji · Tiffany Haddish

NINA ELLIS

41 · Supporting

Free-spirited, unresolved, the return that detonates the group. Ten years of an answer nobody asked for.

Nicole Beharie · Yaya DaCosta

All names presented as creative reference points for tone, age range, and platform fit. Casting subject to availability, financing, and platform approval.

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